



CHAPTER

One

SELENE

THE MAN AT the end of the bar says *condolences* and means *opportunity*.

I know because it has two shapes: in English it's a hand on a shoulder, and in wolf it's the sound a door makes when it unlocks.

He's been here an hour in a good suit and no tie, with a bourbon he ordered by name and hasn't fucking touched. Who orders a bourbon by name and doesn't drink it? He watches the room as if he's working out which chair is about to be empty.

I pour him a refill he didn't ask for because it keeps me close enough to hear.

"Terrible thing, isn't it?" he says to the woman beside him. "A king like that, in his own house."

She nods, and she has no idea what she's nodding at.

"Awful," she says. "Do they know who did it?"

"Wolves, they're saying." He turns his glass. "Aren't they always?"

"Makes you wonder what's next," he says. "For all of us."

In wolf, *all of us* has a fence around it: the pack, the blood, the people who sleep under the same noise, and never the woman on the next stool.

He means his people, and a door has come off its hinges somewhere above him, and he's here to see what falls through.

I wipe the bar in front of him. Does he see me do it?



CHAPTER

Two

LUCIAN

THE DOOR TO my father's study has been unlocked since Tuesday.

I could fix it in an afternoon, but I sit down in my father's chair instead and look at the door from the inside.

He kept this room open because he wanted people to come in. The people who could walk through it without knocking were few enough to count on my fingers, and every one of them was chosen.

Chosen is what I keep getting caught on. Which one of them did he choose wrong?



THEY COME FOR me before noon.

Marguerite first, because Marguerite is always fucking first: my father's sister, twice my age, who has held the council together since Tuesday with nothing but a voice and the correct use of the word *traditionally*.

"You look terrible," she says.

"I've been traveling. Where do you think I've been?"

"You've been sitting in that chair." She crosses to the window and opens the shutter I closed. "Ambroise says you haven't fed."

"Ambroise talks. Doesn't he ever stop?"

"Ambroise is a physician, and you are the last Croix, and you are not starving yourself to death in my brother's chair, do you hear me? And if you'd like a list of the things I've had to say out loud this week to keep that from sounding like a problem, I can provide one."



CHAPTER

Twenty-Four

SELENE

I'VE BEEN READING the ledger in two registers and he's only been reading it in one.

That's the sentence I've been carrying since the archive. He sees the mark and he sees his friend's name underneath it and the weight of that is enough to keep him staring at the same page for an hour.

I see the mark and the name and a third thing: what the mark is doing in my father's handwriting. It's a frequency, more than a signature, because the jobs with the mark get more regular as the years go on. The fees climb, and the climbing tells me what the mark by itself doesn't.

Whoever this client was, my father became more valuable to him over time, not less, not

steady, *more*. The payments rise as a salary rises when the employee starts carrying a secret the employer can't afford to lose.

My father was holding something for Cassian Vale, something worth more every year, something worth killing to keep buried.

I've known it a day longer, because I read the second register while he was still reading the first.

So why didn't I tell him? Was it cruelty? Was it the translator in me, waiting for the whole sentence?

I wasn't protecting Cassian, and I wasn't being kind. I wanted to see Lucian's face when the name arrived on its own. I wanted to know whether the knowledge would break him or sharpen him. The answer is: it sharpened him, and the sharpening cut me, and I don't regret the waiting.



THERE'S A GATHERING in the east wing, though vampires this old don't throw parties. They hold receptions. The court assembles in a long room

with good light and indifferent music and glasses of a red that isn't wine. They stand in clusters and talk about the things they talk about, which are power and money and who has too much of each.

I'm here because Lucian asked me to come, in the voice he uses now, with no *mine* and no command, a question with a shape: *Would you come to this? I'd like you beside me.*

Is he learning? He is.

INTERLUDE I

Cassian

I COULD TELL him tonight.

He is sitting where his father sat, in the chair his father never once turned toward the window, and he has finally asked the right question: who was in the room. He asked it plainly, as Aurelian asked things, and then he did what Aurelian never learned to do.

He waited.

He is very good at waiting, and I taught him that, in a manner of speaking, by being the only man in his life who never filled a silence for him.

The lamp is lit and the decanter is down a finger and the house has gone quiet around us, as it does after the household eats. A boy and his uncle in a warm room, and there is nothing in this evening that is not exactly what it appears to be, except for me.

I taught those hands to hold a blade. Aurelian was busy being a king, so it was me in the courtyard every evening, through all the years that takes, and nobody has ever thanked me for it and I have never asked.

He has his father's hands and none of his father's certainty. That is the whole difference between them, and it is the reason this city is going to survive what is coming.

"Who was in the room?" he says again.

He has asked it again, because he makes men repeat themselves. He has done it since he was small, because a man who hears himself say a thing has to live with having said it.

Why don't I hand him the whole of it now?

Across this desk, in this light, before he has spent a single life on the wrong answer.

How would it go?

Epilogue

WE'RE NOT FINISHED

SELENE

THE APARTMENT is empty and the house is full, and I'm standing between them with a bag over my shoulder.

It's the same bag I carried into Perdido the night I went looking for a way across the water, small, no room for anything except keys and a phone and the ready willingness of a woman who has decided where she's going.

The knife is in the drawer, and the ledger is in the house. The plant is dead and the cup is clean. I washed it this morning, standing at a sink I've stood at for two years. The washing felt like the last sentence of a chapter.

Less an ending than a translation: the same life, in a different language.



DELPHINE CALLED this morning, and it wasn't about Rémy, or the pack, or the bench I sat on. She called because the tea woman in Tremé had a batch ready. Delphine had been buying from her too, and did I want to split the order.

"You drink the tea?" I said.

"My aunt drank it. I drink it because she did, God knows why." A pause. "Is that stupid?"

"No. Is it any good? Tell me the truth, because the last thing you recommended was that bait shop and I'm still mad about the shrimp."

"It tastes like dirt."

"Good dirt. Hell of a recommendation."

The Ghost That Stayed

Chapter Eleven, from her side of the bed

HE SAYS *come here* like a man who has never once had to say it twice.

I should make him. That's what I'm thinking, sitting on my own kitchen floor with my back against the wall and a vampire king propped against my cabinets. He's gray around the mouth and bleeding on my linoleum, and he still says *come here* as if the floor is his and I'm the one visiting.

I should make him say it again. He loves that. *Say it again.* I've heard him do it to me three times since the sun came up.

Instead I get up, because the floor is a stupid place to do this.

“Not here,” I tell him. “The floor is stupid.”

He looks at the floor as though it's been accused of something. Then he gets himself up the cabinet, one piece at a time, and I don't help him. I want to. My hands actually move, and I put them in my back pockets so they'll stop.

He wouldn't forgive me for it. You don't hold a door for a man who owns every door in the city.

He makes it to the bedroom on his own. It takes him longer than the hallway is long.



HE SITS ON the edge of my bed. My cheap frame and my good sheets, the only thing in this apartment I ever spent real money on, and now there's a vampire on them with his shirt half open and blood dried brown down one forearm.

My mother would have had a lot to say about this. None of it in English.

“How do you want to do it?” I ask.

A FIRST LOOK AT BOOK TWO

Vow of Poison

CHAPTER ONE • SILAS

THE WITCH WHO nearly killed my king is making soup.

I can smell it from the road. Onion, bay, the dark roux her grandmother taught her, and something under it that isn't food. Rosemary burned on purpose. She does that when she's worried and doesn't want the house to know.

I've walked past this house most nights for a year.

I walk past because some nights her bedroom window is open, and I can smell her from the gate: rosemary and warm skin and, late, after her lamp goes out, the sharp sweet musk of a woman touching herself in the dark. I know that smell. I've stood under her streetlamp with my cock hard in my trousers and my jaw locked,

listening to her breathing change through the shutters, listening to her come, and then I've walked home.

I've never once gone in.

I tell myself it's the route. It isn't the route. The route goes along the canal and this house is a turn off it, and I take the turn, and I've never once written it down.

Tonight I stop at the gate.



SOMEBODY STOOD on her step.

A man. Good shoes, thin soles, the kind that don't know what mud is. He came up the walk slowly and stopped at the second board, the one that gives, and he stayed on it. Weight on the left foot. Then the right. Then the left again.

He didn't knock.

He wanted her to hear the board and wonder. He stood there long enough for the worry to get into the rosemary.